

India's Cultural Root

1. Introduction

- Indian culture is several thousand years old and has many roots and branches.
 - These roots include art, literature, science, medicine, religion, governance, and schools of thought.
 - Some cultural roots trace back to the ancient Indus (Harappan or Sindhu-Sarasvati) Civilization.
-

2. The Vedas and Vedic Culture

What are the Vedas?

- "Veda" means knowledge (from Sanskrit *vid*).
- Four Vedas:
 1. Rig Veda
 2. Yajur Veda
 3. Sama Veda
 4. Atharva Veda
- They are India's oldest texts and among the oldest in the world.
- Consist of hymns, prayers, poems, and songs transmitted orally for generations.
- Composed by Rishis (male sages) and Rishikas (female sages).

Important Vedic Ideas

- Belief in Ritam (truth and cosmic order).
- Deities included Indra, Agni, Varuna, Sarasvati, Ushas, etc.
- Unity behind all divine forms:

Ekam Sat Vipra Bahudha Vadanti

"Truth is one, sages call it by many names."

Vedic Values

- Truth (*Satya*)
 - Harmony
 - Unity
 - Cooperation among people
-

3. Vedic Society

- Society organized into Janas (clans) such as Bharatas, Purus, Kurus, and Yadus.
 - Terms like:
 - Raja – ruler or king
 - Sabha and Samiti – assemblies
 - Occupations included:
 - Farmers
 - Potters
 - Weavers
 - Carpenters
 - Healers
 - Priests
 - Dancers
-

4. Upanishads and Vedanta

New Concepts Introduced

- Karma – actions and their consequences.
- Rebirth – repeated births.
- Atman – the inner self.
- Brahman – the supreme divine reality.

Famous Mahavakyas

- Aham Brahmasmi – "I am Brahman."
- Tat Tvam Asi – "You are That."

Main Teaching

- Everything in the universe is interconnected and divine.
 - Prayer:
Sarve Bhavantu Sukhinah
"May all beings be happy."
-

5. Yoga

- Developed from Vedic traditions.
 - Aims at realizing the unity of Atman and Brahman.
 - Focuses on self-discipline and spiritual growth.
-

Buddhism

Founder

- Siddhartha Gautama (The Buddha)
- Born in Lumbini (present-day Nepal).

Important Events

- Saw:
 - An old man
 - A sick man
 - A dead person
 - An ascetic
- Left palace life in search of truth.
- Attained enlightenment under a Pipal tree at Bodh Gaya (Bihar).

Main Teachings

- Suffering is caused by:
 - Ignorance (Avidya)
 - Attachment
- Practice:
 - Self-discipline
 - Truthfulness

- **Compassion**
- **Ahimsa (non-hurting)**

Sangha

- **Community of monks (Bhikshus) and nuns (Bhikshunis).**
- **Spread Buddhist teachings across Asia.**

Important Quote

"Conquering oneself is greater than conquering a thousand men."

Jainism

Founder

- **Vardhamana Mahavira**
- **Born near Vaishali (Bihar).**

Important Events

- **Left home at age 30.**
- **Practised severe asceticism for 12 years.**
- **Attained supreme wisdom.**
- **Became known as Mahavira (Great Hero).**

Main Teachings

Ahimsa

- **Do not harm any living being.**

Anekantavada

- **Truth has many aspects.**
- **No single viewpoint contains complete truth.**

Aparigraha

- **Non-possession.**
- **Avoid unnecessary material attachment.**

Core Belief

- **All living beings are interconnected and interdependent.**

Meaning of "Jain"

- **Derived from Jina (conqueror).**
 - **One who conquers ignorance and attachment.**
-

Common Ideas in Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism

These traditions share:

- **Dharma**
 - **Karma**
 - **Rebirth**
 - **Search for truth**
 - **Removal of suffering**
 - **Removal of ignorance**
 - **Ethical living**
 - **Compassion and non-violence**
-

Folk and Tribal Traditions

Tribes

- **Communities sharing:**
 - **Common ancestry**
 - **Culture**
 - **Language**
 - **Traditions**
- **India had 705 tribes (2011 Census).**

Tribal Beliefs

- **Nature is sacred.**
- **Worship:**
 - **Mountains**
 - **Rivers**
 - **Trees**
 - **Animals**

- **Stones**

Examples

- **Jagannath of Odisha is believed to have tribal origins.**
- **Toda tribe (Tamil Nadu) considers mountain peaks sacred.**
- **Donyi-Polo (Arunachal Pradesh): Sun-Moon deity.**
- **Singbonga (Munda and Santhal tribes): Supreme creator deity.**

Contribution to Indian Culture

- **Folk and tribal traditions influenced Hinduism.**
- **Hindu traditions also influenced tribal cultures.**
- **Exchange of stories, rituals, deities, and beliefs enriched Indian civilization.**

Important Terms

Term	Meaning
Veda	Knowledge
Rishi	Male sage
Rishika	Female sage
Ritam	Cosmic order and truth
Karma	Actions and consequences
Rebirth	Birth again after death
Brahman	Supreme divine reality
Atman	Inner self
Ahimsa	Non-violence / non-hurting
Sangha	Buddhist monastic community
Anekantavada	Many-sided truth
Aparigraha	Non-possession
Ascetic	Person practicing strict self-discipline